



Office Peacocking

Can it Lure Employees Back to Office?

Case Study

This case was written by **Dr. Simple Verma** and reviewed by **Dr. A. Saravanan Naidu**, Amity Research Centers Headquarter, Bangalore. It is intended to be used as the basis for class discussion rather than to illustrate either effective or ineffective handling of a management situation. The case was compiled from published sources.

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*"Employers must go beyond instituting the flexible arrangements today's employees demand — they must also be 'intentional' about how company headquarters look and operate now."*¹

— Owl Labs' 'State of Remote Work' Report

*"People are now actually wondering how we can make better workspaces. And I think it's a good moment to talk to leaders about it."*²

— Alejandra Albarran, Vice President Workspace Strategy and Design, ROOM³

*"Office peacocking can all too easily be botched... The best peacocking is when it isn't just colorful feathers outspread, but genuine improvements... You don't want employees to feel you are putting window dressing on an office environment that is no better—and may even be worse—than what they had before the pandemic."*⁴

— Margery Weinstein, Contributing Editor, *Training Magazine*

Due to the COVID-19 pandemic, the world witnessed its greatest experiment in remote work ever, with hundreds of millions of workers used to work from home (WFH).⁵ After the pandemic ended, 'many companies were eager to get their teams back into the office environment'. However, employees were reluctant to return to office and were in favour of remote work.⁶ Companies were trying hard to entice employees back to the offices and were becoming creative.⁷ To make the workplaces more inviting, efforts were made to infuse fun and innovation into office spaces, leading to the new trend called 'office peacocking'. Offices

¹ Case Tony, "The rise of 'office peacocking,' and how it can lure back — and inspire — employees", <https://www.worklife.news/spaces/the-rise-of-office-peacocking-and-how-it-can-lure-back-and-inspire-employees/>, March 20th 2023

² "Word Wiz: Office Peacocking", <https://www.td.org/magazines/td-magazine/word-wiz-office-peacocking>, June 30th 2023

³ A New York-based design firm.

⁴ Weinstein Margery, "The Right Way to Do 'Office Peacocking'", <https://trainingmag.com/the-right-way-to-do-office-peacocking/>, March 25th 2024

⁵ Muller Jon, "The 3 Biggest Coworking Trends Shaping up for 2022", <https://www.workdesign.com/2021/09/the-3-biggest-coworking-trends-shaping-up-for-2022/>, September 22nd 2021

⁶ Sorensen Katherine, "5 Reasons for Employees Not Wanting to Return to the Office (And How to Address Them)", <https://www.officespacesoftware.com/blog/5-reasons-for-employees-not-wanting-to-return-to-the-office-and-how-to-address-them/>, October 4th 2023

⁷ Burton Amber and Confino Paolo, "Leaders are designing offices to be more 'homely' to entice workers to return", <https://fortune.com/2022/09/08/leaders-are-designing-offices-to-be-more-homely-to-entice-workers-to-return/>, September 8th 2022

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were transformed into spaces that resembled homes rather than conventional workplaces.⁸ Can office peacocking help bring employees back to the office?⁹

Office Peacocking: An Emerging Trend in the Workplace

The COVID-19 pandemic had radically altered the landscape of work since early 2020.¹⁰ It forced businesses to adapt to remote work setups to continue functioning and to ensure the safety of employees.¹¹ Additionally, this shift gave workers greater flexibility and obliterated long commutes to the offices. Several companies re-evaluated their workplace policies after the COVID-19 threat receded in mid-2022.¹² The shuttered offices had reopened post-pandemic, but not all employees were eager to return to work. In addition to health concerns and rusty social skills, many workers did not want to return due to fear of losing the flexibility they gained from WFH. They were reluctant to give up the work-life balance that they discovered during remote work set-ups.¹³ Many employees want to persist working remotely.¹⁴ According to commercial real estate firm JLL, “office occupancy numbers have hovered between 40 percent and 60 percent of what they were before the pandemic.”¹⁵

Frank Weishaupt (Weishaupt), CEO of Owl Labs¹⁶, stated, “We just passed the fourth year anniversary of the pandemic and many employers still haven’t yet given up on trying to return to pre-pandemic policies, despite our data showing that many employees will make sacrifices to achieve flexibility in where they work, as 62% would take a pay cut of 10% or more to remain hybrid.”¹⁷

Even though employees worldwide had got used to WFH, employers had not surrendered themselves to the inevitability of remote work.¹⁸ Bosses were still trying to figure out ‘ways to bring back the pre-pandemic norm of employees spending 40 hours a week in offices and cubicles’.¹⁹ Companies were striving hard to get employees back to the offices, similar to pre-

⁸ Srivastava Samridhhi, “Office Peacocking vs Coffee Badging: New back-to-office trends you need to know about”, <https://www.peoplesmatters.in/article/life-at-work/office-peacocking-vs-coffee-badging-new-back-to-office-trends-you-need-to-know-about-39167>, October 6th 2023

⁹ “Can ‘office peacocking’ help bring folks back to the office?”, <https://www2.smartbrief.com/sharedSummary/index.jsp?copyId=88A3A888-1DA2-4A09-982B-F3DC6F25D8B8&issueId=ED89F288-17BF-40F4-B879-D1324F5283B3&briefId=EFB0EF8E-4F58-4C01-8C3B-4ADDF7829AC6&launched=true>, March 20th 2023

¹⁰ Ma Mark and Ding Yuye, “Return to Office Mandates Don’t Improve Employee or Company Performance”, <https://business.pitt.edu/return-to-office-mandates-dont-improve-employee-or-company-performance/>

¹¹ “5 Reasons for Employees Not Wanting to Return to the Office (And How to Address Them)”, op.cit.

¹² “Return to Office Mandates Don’t Improve Employee or Company Performance”, op.cit.

¹³ Cuck Elizabeth, “Office buildings are opening back up. Not all employees want to return”, <https://www.nbcnews.com/news/us-news/office-buildings-are-opening-back-not-all-employees-want-return-n1262647>, April 5th 2021

¹⁴ Stevens Amanda, “15 advantages and disadvantages of remote work”, <https://www.techtarget.com/whatis/feature/15-advantages-and-disadvantages-of-remote-work>, July 16th 2021

¹⁵ “Word Wiz: Office Peacocking”, op.cit.

¹⁶ It is a company that makes 360° video conferencing devices called the ‘Meeting Owl’ for Remote collaboration for Working from anywhere (WFA).

¹⁷ Dr. Robinson Bryan, “The Rise Of ‘Office Peacocking’ In The Workplace In 2024”, <https://www.forbes.com/sites/bryanrobinson/2024/03/20/the-rise-of-office-peacocking-in-the-workplace-in-2024/?sh=2879129d521d>, March 20th 2024

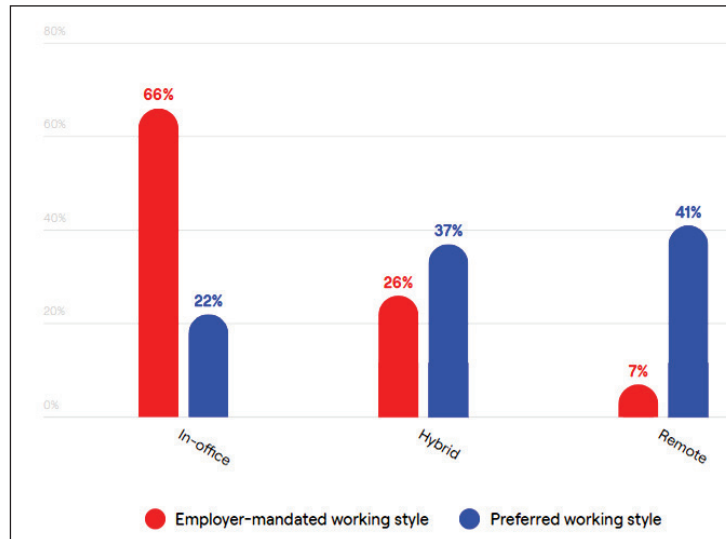
¹⁸ Gensing-Pophal Lin, “4 Key Challenges Employers Face in Back-to-Office Efforts”, <https://hrdailyadvisor.blr.com/2023/03/01/fourchallenges-employers-face-in-back-to-office-efforts-key/>, March 1st 2023

¹⁹ Agee Chris, “How ‘Office Peacocking’ Aims To Coax Workers Out Of Their Homes”, <https://earlychirp.com/story/2023/04/how-office-peacocking-aims-to-coax-workers-out-of-their-homes>, April 5th 2023

pandemic times.²⁰ Many companies enforced 'return-to-office mandates' and switched stances after employee pushback.²¹ (Exhibit I).

Exhibit I

Owl Lab's Survey Result on Workers' Preferred Working Style Compared to Employer Mandate



Source: "State of Hybrid Work 2023", <https://owllabs.com/state-of-hybrid-work/2023>

Neither the remote workers nor the employers who wanted staff in office seats were willing to back down. The battle was at the forefront and centre of many companies. Employers were increasingly looking for incentives to bring employees back into the office as the debate on remote work vs. in-office work raged on.²²

The Owl Labs survey report, conducted among 2,000 full-time employees in the US, discovered why employees were resisting going back. Weishaupt informed, "People don't want to spend time and money on frequent office pilgrimages if they're just going to be sitting on the same video calls they'd be doing in the comfort of their own homes or on tasks that they feel less productive doing from the office. The data shows that many companies have more work to do to provide an attractive, productive and stress-free office environment that makes employees want to gather."²³ (Annexure I).

After years of WFH, 'employees needed extra incentive to reacclimate to an office setting'. Some employers attempted to quell the rebellion by redecorating the offices. Employers had opted to revamp their offices, replacing 'sterile cubicle farms with inspiring décor'. These revamped workspaces prioritised collaboration and comfort with the 'intention of easing employees' transition from home back to a corporate environment'.²⁴ They challenged

²⁰ Majumdar Debleena, "Coffee badging, office peacocking — the new tools being used in return-to-office mandates", <https://economictimes.indiatimes.com/jobs/hr-policies-trends/coffee-badging-office-peacocking-the-new-tools-being-used-in-return-to-office-mandates/articleshow/104844432.cms?from=mdr>, October 31st 2023

²¹ "State of Hybrid Work 2023", <https://owllabs.com/state-of-hybrid-work/2023>

²² Abelis Viesturs, "5 unexpected incentives to get employees back into the office — willingly", <https://deskttime.com/blog/incentives-to-get-employees-back-into-office>, February 6th 2024

²³ Dr. Robinson Bryan, "'Coffee Badging,' New Coping Trend To Get Around In-Office Mandates", <https://www.forbes.com/sites/bryanrobinson/2023/09/29/coffee-badging-new-coping-trend-to-get-around-in-office-mandates/?sh=43f528f47230>, September 29th 2023

²⁴ "Evolving the Workplace Through Rebellious Trends", <https://martisearch.com/evolving-the-workplace-through-rebellious-trends/>

traditional office design by creating aesthetically pleasing spaces that were functional.²⁵ This practice of decorating offices with fun decor and providing perks like free food and coffee had been dubbed as office peacocking.²⁶

This trend intended to metamorphose offices into spaces that appeared like homes rather than conventional corporate settings.²⁷ The companies overhauled their offices to make them enticing.²⁸ The modern office began to feature ‘cosy couches, bright and inspiring decor, and even living plants’. These elements were conscientiously chosen to kindle a sense of ‘warmth and comfort’ to encourage employees to return to the workplace.²⁹ Founder and CEO of Austin-based Teifke Real Estate, Matt Teifke, commented, “Employers are creating more magnetic spaces —incorporating elements like standing desks and soft-seating areas; bright, colorful accents and artwork; and biophilic design touches like plants, natural light, and nature-themed fabrics.”³⁰

Some offices resembled ‘upscale lounges or living rooms with sofas, rugs, video monitors and more’.³¹ This represented a shift in how workplaces were designed. This trend aimed to create a welcoming and enjoyable work environment, recognising the changing dynamics of the workplace.³² Riley King, Design Director at Gensler Chicago, an architecture firm, noted, “Employers now are also looking to provide resources and services that you typically can’t get at home.” The offices had started looking like airport lounges.³³ However, this transformation was not at all hassle free. Restructuring office space came at a cost and a considerable investment for companies.³⁴ In order to ‘achieve the desired aesthetic and functionality, companies assisting in this change charged substantial fees’.³⁵ The companies were betting big on designing spaces that would attract employees back.³⁶ The companies hoped that the collaboration and teamwork that might arise from a welcoming environment would justify the investment.³⁷ (Annexure II).

Can Office Peacocking bring Employees Back to Workplace?

The employer’s investment in office peacocking was a strategic move to encourage employees to return to physical workplaces.³⁸ YPulse’s³⁹ Employment and Career Goals report showed

²⁵ Srivastava Samridhi, “Workplace trends induced by the Great Office Return - Peacocking vs Coffee Badging”, <https://www.peoplemattersglobal.com/article/life-at-work/the-great-office-return-induced-workplace-trends-peacocking-vs-coffee-badging-39301>, October 23rd 2023

²⁶ “The new office slang: buzzwords you should know”, <https://resources.owllabs.com/blog/new-office-buzzwords>, August 16th 2023

²⁷ “Office Peacocking vs Coffee Badging: New back-to-office trends you need to know about”, op.cit.

²⁸ Mensik Hailey, “Why more offices are resembling airport lounges with concierge services”, <https://www.worklife.news/spaces/why-more-offices-are-resembling-airport-lounges-with-concierge-services/>, May 1st 2023

²⁹ “Workplace trends induced by the Great Office Return - Peacocking vs Coffee Badging”, op.cit.

³⁰ “The rise of ‘office peacocking,’ and how it can lure back — and inspire — employees”, op.cit.

³¹ “Coffee badging, office peacocking — the new tools being used in return-to-office mandates”, op.cit.

³² “Workplace trends induced by the Great Office Return - Peacocking vs Coffee Badging”, op.cit.

³³ “Why more offices are resembling airport lounges with concierge services”, op.cit.

³⁴ “Office Peacocking vs. Coffee Badging: Who’s Winning?”, <https://allthingstalent.org/office-peacocking-vs-coffee-badging-whos-winning/2023/11/24/>, November 24th 2023

³⁵ “Office Peacocking vs Coffee Badging: New back-to-office trends you need to know about”, op.cit.

³⁶ “Office Peacocking vs. Coffee Badging: Who’s Winning?” op.cit.

³⁷ “How ‘Office Peacocking’ Aims To Coax Workers Out Of Their Homes”, op.cit.

³⁸ “Office Peacocking vs. Coffee Badging: Who’s Winning?”, op.cit.

³⁹ It is a US based market research company focussing on Gen Z & Millennials.

that most young workers preferred 'glamorous office spaces'.⁴⁰ Raj Tanwar, HR Head of Advantage Club⁴¹, said companies were 'transforming their offices to lure Boomers, Gen Z, Gen X' and others. It was intended to bring them back to offices and end WFH. He surmised, "This trend sought to reshape offices into an environment solely based on desire, not by utility. Break-out spaces meant for hurdles closely resemble swanky hotels and clubs, departing from the conventional corporate setting of cubicles and the clacks of typing. In short, it's time for employers to create a FOMO (fear of missing out) among employees to bring them to work... The play is not only happening around infrastructure; rather moves are being made to add newer benefits, flex policies and even relaxing daily productivity norms without losing focus on the results thru ROWE (result-oriented work environment)."⁴²

Peacocking at the office could potentially entice young workers from their WFH comfort zones. Young workers wanted to work in spaces that look like a living room featured in 'Architectural Digest', especially after becoming accustomed to the comforts of WFH.⁴³ According to Viesturs Abelis, Writer at Desktimes⁴⁴, "By investing in high-quality office equipment and design, companies can turn them into a place where employees work more efficiently and enjoy the time they spend there, serving as a good strategy for how to bring employees back to the office."⁴⁵ Keeping the workplace relaxed had been a priority, and it was a welcome change for those who spent long hours at work. But it was critical to assess what really helped the employees in such a situation.⁴⁶

Though an attractive office was nice, Weishaupt stated that Owl Lab's report investigated factors that 'mattered the most to hybrid employees when it came to returning to the office'. He pointed out, "Companies paying for commuting costs (38%) is at the top of the list, followed by greater privacy at the office [e.g. dedicated offices, more phone booths] (34%), and having a way to know when people they want to see will be there (33%). We also found that it might be a good time to kill the dress code, as one in four employees (24%) said they would be enticed to go to the office if they were able to wear whatever they wanted."⁴⁷ (Exhibit II).

Superficial perks such as free cold brew no longer sufficed and did not meet the remote worker's needs.⁴⁸ A compelling factor influencing the decision to return to the physical workplace was the 'sense of belonging' induced by office culture, including 'team bonding, active participation in company events, and robust professional relationships'.⁴⁹ Dave Wilkin, Founder of Ten Thousand Coffees⁵⁰, opined, "Employees need actual reasons to come to the office such as in-person brainstorming sessions, in-person coffee chats with executives and

⁴⁰ "Office peacocking' has the potential to lure young workers out of their work-from-home comfort", <https://www.ypulse.com/newsfeed/2023/03/21/office-peacocking-has-the-potential-to-lure-young-workers-out-of-their-work-from-home-comfort/>, March 21st 2023

⁴¹ It is a global employee engagement platform.

⁴² "Coffee badging, office peacocking — the new tools being used in return-to-office mandates", op.cit.

⁴³ "Office peacocking' has the potential to lure young workers out of their work-from-home comfort", op.cit.

⁴⁴ It is a company engaged in designing employee computer monitoring software.

⁴⁵ "5 unexpected incentives to get employees back into the office — willingly", op.cit.

⁴⁶ Majumdar Debleena, "Career Wrap: Terms that defined Work and the workplace in 2023", <https://m.economictimes.com/jobs/hr-policies-trends/career-wrap-terms-that-defined-work-and-the-workplace-in-2023/articleshow/106292531.cms>, December 26th 2023

⁴⁷ "The Rise Of 'Office Peacocking' In The Workplace In 2024", op.cit.

⁴⁸ Dunn Zach, "The future of employee perks in the post-pandemic workplace", <https://venturebeat.com/datadecisionmakers/the-future-of-employee-perks-in-the-post-pandemic-workplace/>, February 16th 2022

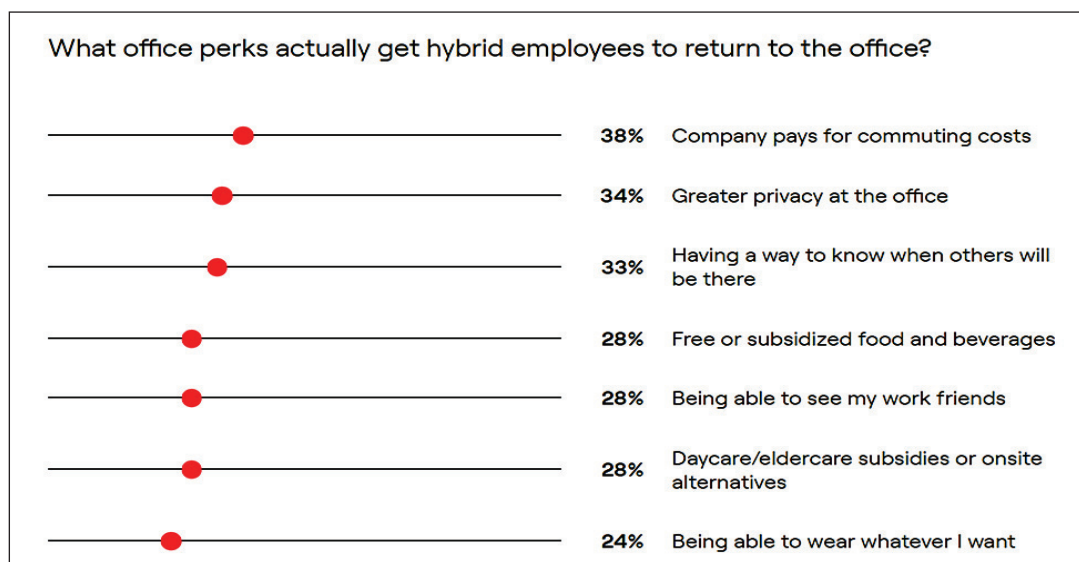
⁴⁹ "Office Peacocking vs. Coffee Badging: Who's Winning?", op.cit.

⁵⁰ A mentoring and networking platform.

mentor relationships based on complementary in-office days.”⁵¹ In a dynamic era, offering up cosmetic benefits without providing relevant perks that ‘truly benefited employees was no longer sufficient’.⁵²

Exhibit II

Owl Labs’ Report Survey Findings on Office Perks that Can Lure Hybrid Employees to Offices



Source: Srivastava Samriddhi, “Office Peacocking vs Coffee Badging: New back-to-office trends you need to know about”, <https://www.peoplesmatters.in/article/life-at-work/office-peacocking-vs-coffee-badging-new-back-to-office-trends-you-need-to-know-about-39167>, October 6th 2023

Weishaupt cited that employees were on the lookout for strategies to escape the artificial facades of office peacocking. He commented, “Job sharing and side hustles are making a comeback. Almost half of employees (46%) have at least one additional job or ‘side hustle’ outside of their main full-time job, and 68% of them are full-time in-office workers. Plus, there’s a rise in the concept of ‘polyworking’—when employees have two or more jobs and the trend of ‘calling in healthy’—the practice of pushing through work when you’re sick so on days when you’re feeling great, you can use that sick time off for something fun and/or relaxing... Full-time office workers are more than twice as likely to have an additional job than hybrid and remote workers. These trends, underscore that return-to-office mandates are not the way to get people back to the office. They clearly don’t work.”⁵³

Industry experts raised concerns. Even though office peacocking had its advantages, it was also important to acknowledge the potential downsides. Peacocking might not fit every organisation’s culture. These trends might seem forced in some workplaces, ‘creating a disconnect between employees and the company’s ethos’. Similarly, office peacocking could create an atmosphere where ‘appearances mattered more than quality’.⁵⁴

⁵¹ Munk Winokur Cheryl, “The CEO ‘return to office or else’ is having limited success in 2024”, <https://www.cnbc.com/2024/02/04/the-ceo-return-to-office-or-else-is-having-limited-success-this-year.html>, February 5th 2024

⁵² Merriel Grant, “Is the Era of Swanky Office Perks Coming to an End?”, <https://b2bhq.com.au/death-of-office-perks/>, June 5th 2023

⁵³ “The Rise Of ‘Office Peacocking’ In The Workplace In 2024”, op.cit.

⁵⁴ “Coffee Badging and Office Peacocking: On-Going Work Trends!”, <https://www.truworthwellness.com/blog/coffee-badging-and-office-peacocking/>, February 1st 2024

Focussing on short-term benefits to lure employees without incorporating them into the company's strategic mission and operating expenses could be detrimental.⁵⁵ All Things Talent⁵⁶ Team cautioned, "The escalating costs involved in redesigning and maintaining these lavish office environments might soon render this battle redundant. As companies grapple with mounting expenses, the trend towards remote or hybrid work setups may prevail, placing the balance between employee comfort and the allure of the physical office in a precarious position, potentially tilting the scales toward a more flexible work future."⁵⁷ In the rising post-pandemic office culture, the value of perks had changed.⁵⁸ Leaders had a myriad of 'decisions and challenges to juggle' in fashioning a return to the offices.⁵⁹ Truworth Wellness, a corporate wellness company in India, noted, "Employee well-being is not just about a fancy desk and a comfy chair; it's about holistic support... Creating a workplace that people love is awesome, but it's crucial to do it with the right spirit. Think of it like building a lasting friendship – genuine, thoughtful, and for the long haul. In the quest to attract and keep awesome employees, remember the golden rule – it's not just about the perks; it's about the spirit behind them."⁶⁰ Was the office peacocking trend just an illusion to find work-life balance? Are employees actually going back?⁶¹ Can the 'design of the office play a role in bringing employees back into the office, or was this a lost cause'?⁶²

⁵⁵ "Coffee badging, office peacocking — the new tools being used in return-to-office mandates", op.cit.

⁵⁶ All Things Talent knowledge platform is an initiative of Naukri Hiring Suite for professionals to network and share ideas.

⁵⁷ "Office Peacocking vs. Coffee Badging: Who's Winning?" op.cit.

⁵⁸ "Is the Era of Swanky Office Perks Coming to an End?", op.cit.

⁵⁹ Barry Kristin and Wigert Ben, "Going Back to Work in the Office: It Has to Be Worth It", <https://www.gallup.com/workplace/349772/going-back-work-office-worth.aspx>, May 17th 2021

⁶⁰ "Coffee Badging and Office Peacocking: On-Going Work Trends!", op.cit.

⁶¹ "The Rise Of 'Office Peacocking' In The Workplace In 2024", op.cit.

⁶² "Competing with WFH: How Companies are Designing Swanky Offices to Entice Employees", <https://marketscale.com/industries/building-management/competing-with-wfh-how-companies-are-designing-swanky-offices-to-entice-employees/>, April 11th 2023

Annexure I

Key Findings of Owl Labs' Survey Report on State of Hybrid Work 2023

1. 69% of respondents believe that their company is requiring them to work from the office because of **traditional work expectations**
2. 23% of employees **changed companies** in 2023, and this was more common among full-time office workers (26%) than hybrid/remote workers (17%)
3. 1 in 3 workers (33%) spend 31-45 minutes **commuting one-way**
4. Almost half (46%) of workers are **"polyworking"** with a side hustle or additional job, and a further 36% plan on starting one in the future
5. 1 in 4 workers (25%) would be willing to sacrifice 15% of their annual salary for **flexible working hours**
6. More than half (58%) of hybrid employees **"coffee badge"** - also known as showing face at the office and then leaving
7. 56% of workers said that their level of **work-related stress** has increased since last year
8. 94% of workers say they could be **convinced to come to the office**
9. If no longer able to work remotely, 29% of hybrid and remote workers would **expect a pay increase** to make up for additional costs
10. Only 37% of employers have upgraded their **video meeting technology** in 2023
11. 54% believe that **business trips** in their organization have returned to pre-pandemic levels
12. 68% of managers believe that their hybrid/remote working employees are missing out on **impromptu or in-formal feedback**
13. 80% of workers experience **lost time due to technical difficulties** during online/hybrid meetings
14. 44% of workers said **generative AI** will help them do their job faster and more effectively in the next five years
15. 64% of respondents feel that their company uses too many **communication platforms**

Source: "State of Hybrid Work 2023", <https://owllabs.com/state-of-hybrid-work/2023>

Annexure II

The Redesigned Office Spaces



Source: "Coffee Badging and Office Peacocking: On-Going Work Trends!", <https://www.truworthwellness.com/blog/coffee-badging-and-office-peacocking/>, February 1st 2024